

LIVE



NEWSPAPER

19th January, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

3rd WEEK



SYRIA ISSUE & KURDS

UPSC CSE – GS III

GS III ... TERRORISM



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

19th JANUARY, 2018

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SINGLE FILE

Long game in Syria

The U.S.'s planned Kurdish-led border force would set the stage for a prolonged presence in the country

STANLEY JOHNS



The U.S.'s decision to create a new Kurdish-led border force in north-eastern Syria to defend the areas captured from the Islamic State (IS) could open a new phase of conflict in the country. Swatches of territory on the Syrian-Turkish border, mostly populated by the Kurds, are now controlled by the U.S.-backed Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), a Kurdish-Arab militia that was in the forefront of the land war against the IS. With the planned 30,000-strong border force, which will mostly draw fighters from the SDF, the U.S. is not only institutionalising the militia, but also setting the stage for a prolonged stay in Syria.

From the outset of the Syrian civil war, the U.S. has been on the losing side. The Obama administration had called for the resignation of President Bashar al-Assad and was supporting anti-Assad rebels as well as running a clandestine CIA run programme to arm them. But the 2015 Russian intervention in Syria sabotaged those plans and helped Mr. Assad consolidate power and recapture most of the territory lost to rebels and jihadists. Then the U.S. shifted its focus to defeating the IS and establishing its influence in the country. In that bid, Kurds, who were facing IS advances, proved helpful. At present, the country is divided into three major camps. Most cities and population centres, including the Mediterranean coast, are controlled by the regime, while rebels and al-Qaeda-linked jihadists run Idlib province (which is now under attack by regime-Russian forces). In north-eastern Syria, Kurds have carved out a semi-autonomous region. It's here that the U.S. is cultivating its proxies.

The U.S.'s plan is to carve out a sphere of influence in the middle of West Asia's most dangerous conflict and have it guarded by the battle-hardened Kurdish forces. This enclave could help the U.S. in designing future plans in the region. But the move carries great risks. First, Turkey, an American ally and a NATO member, is already angry. Turkey, which fights a Kurdish insurgency on its soil, sees any further empowerment of the Syrian Kurds as an immediate threat to security, and has vowed to fight the new "terrorist" army. If Ankara attacks the border force, that would raise tensions between the U.S. and Turkey further.

Second, throughout the civil war, the Syrian regime and the Kurds maintained a complex relationship. They were hostile to each other, but never fought against each other, barring some isolated incidents. Syrian Kurds, unlike their Iraqi counterparts, do not demand independence. Rather, they emphasise on autonomy and a federated post-war state structure. These are the issues that should be discussed as part of any final settlement between the regime and the Kurds. But the latest U.S. plans pre-empt any such future deal. This will keep Syria divided forever, leaving the Kurds fully dependent on U.S. aid in the wake of increased regional tensions, while the U.S. gets another foothold for its West Asian geopolitical manoeuvring.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

18th January, 2018

6 Long game in Syria - Stanly Johny

...Contd.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1978

18th January, 2018

The U.S.'s planned Kurdish-led border force would set the stage for a prolonged presence in the country

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6 Should the four SC judges have dissented publicly?

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DEMAND FOR KURDISTAN





NEWS REPORT

- U.S. decided to create a new Kurdish-led border force in Northeastern Syria to defend the areas captured from the Islamic State.
- The territory on the Syrian-Turkish border, mostly populated by the Kurds, is now controlled by the U.S.-backed Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), a Kurdish-Arab militia that was in the forefront of the land war against the IS.



KURDISTAN

- Official borders of the Region of Iraqi Kurdistan
- Territory controlled by Iraqi Kurdistan
- Territory claimed by Iraqi Kurdistan

SYRIA

IRAQ

IRAN

JORDAN

Israel

KUWAIT

Cyprus

Lebanon

Sea

Aqaba





Bashar al-Assad
President , Syria



WHAT IS THE GROUND REALITY IN SYRIA?

- 1** Russia entered the Syrian civil war in 2015.
- 2** Subsequently, it tilted the scales in favour of Syrian Government forces led by Bashar al-Assad.

- 3** U.S. and NATO allies were supporting opposition forces in Syria along with Saudi Arabia (the opposition forces are primarily Sunni led).
- 4** After the entry of Russia, almost a decisive victory emerged with Syrian Government Forces.
- 5** This is considered as set back for US led forces, who were supporting the opposition.
- 6** Now, US wants to stay longer with Syria and that is the reason, why it is backing the SDF.

THREE GROUPS IN SYRIA

GROUP 1

Most cities including the Mediterranean coast are controlled by the Government Forces.



Bashar al-Assad
President , Syria

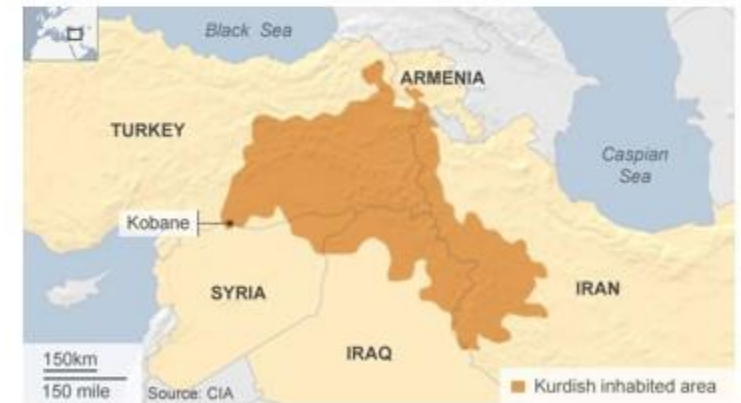
GROUP 2

Rebel forces as well as Al-Qaeda linked Jihadists are running Idlib province.



GROUP 3

In north eastern Syria, Kurds have carved out a semi-autonomous region. Here the U.S. is cultivating its proxies.



WHY THIS IS EXPECTED TO CREATE MORE TROUBLE IN THE REGION?



- 1 Already there is a referendum in Iraq for separate Kurdish country.
- 2 Kurds are spread across primarily four countries in a contiguous region.
- 3 Turkey an American ally and a NATO member fights Kurdish militancy on its soil.
- 4 Empowerment of the Syrian-Kurds will be an immediate threat to Turkey.
- 5 Over all, if Kurds are strengthened that will not be palatable to all the four countries in the region i.e., Turkey, Syria, Iran and Iraq.

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